High Reliability with a Focus on Just Culture in Inpatient Hospital Pharmacy

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Learning Objectives

- Define high reliability organizations and their core principles
- Describe just culture and its role in medication safety
- Identify practical strategies to implement just culture in pharmacy system
- Recognize how safety culture can result in continuous improvement

Opening Narrative : A Near Miss Story

During a busy evening shift, a pharmacy technician dispensed a look-alike, sound-alike medication. A vigilant nurse caught the error at bedside before it was administered.

The Old Way:	The New Way (Just Culture):
• Blame the technician • Disciplinary action or written reprimand • Fear of reporting future errors	• Technician encouraged to report near miss • ERS reported at Multidisciplinary safety huddle • Root cause analysis performed • System level changes implemented • Technician received support and education • Event became a learning opportunity for others

What is a High Reliability Organization

High reliability organizations are institutions that operate in high-risk environments with extremely low error rates.

Examples: Commercial aviation, nuclear power plants, aircraft carriers

Healthcare Goal: Achieve similar safety levels in our complex and dynamic hospital environment

High Reliability Principles

Principles of anticipation
Anticipate/avoid

- Preoccupation with Failure
- Reluctance To Simplify
- Sensitivity to Operations

Principles of containment
Contain/manage

- Commitment to Resilience
- Deference to Expertise

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High Reliability Principles

Preoccupation with Failure:

- Treat near misses as learning opportunities, not success
- Constant vigilance for potential errors

Sensitivity to Operations:

- Maintaining real-time awareness of medication workflows
- Monitor inventory, communication and processes continuously

The Five Principles of High Reliability CONTD

Reluctance to Simplify:

- Avoid quick explanation and dismissal of errors
- Conduct thorough root cause analysis

Deference to Expertise:

- Empower those with knowledge, regardless of hierarchy

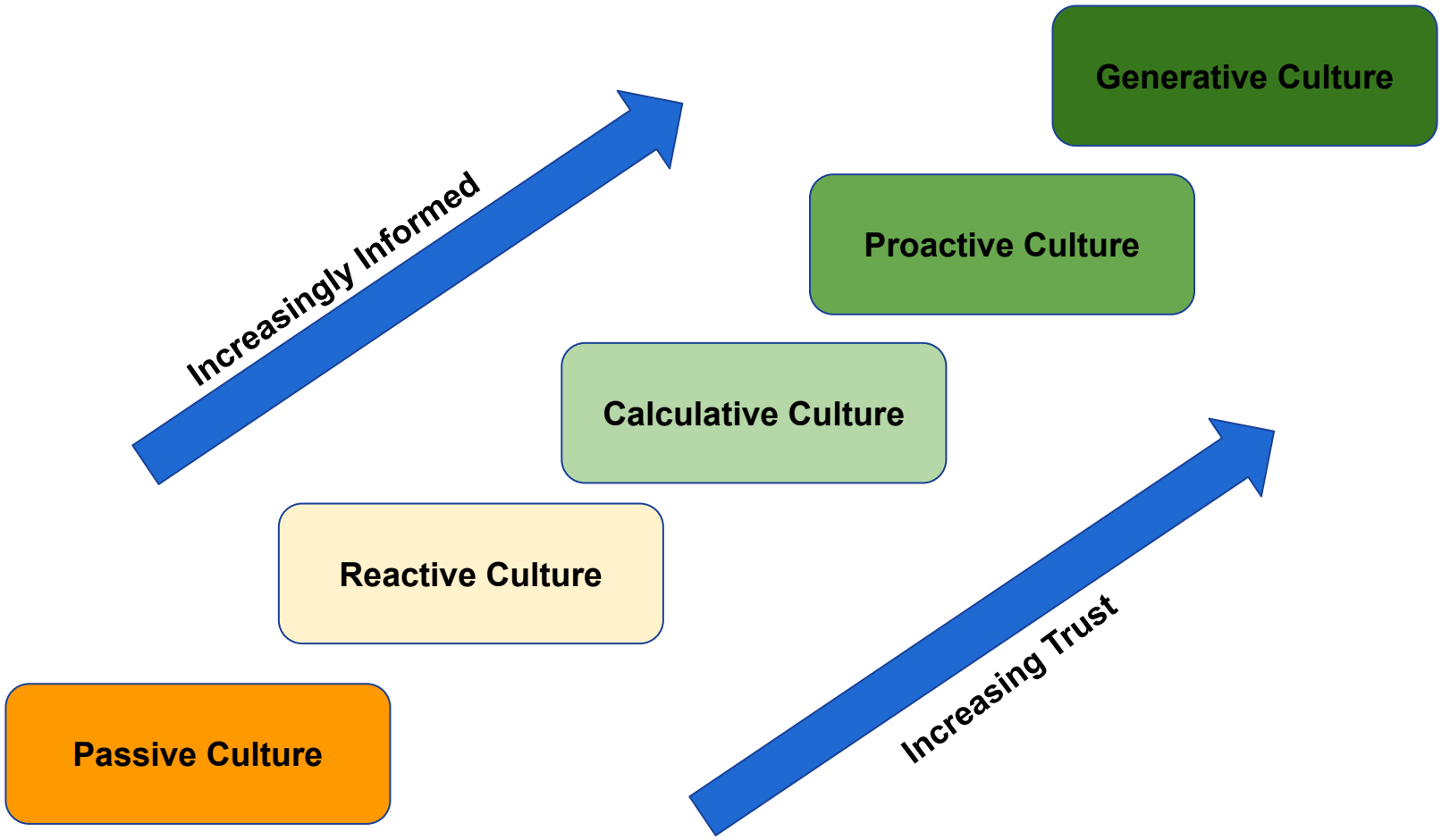
Commitment to Resilience:

- Adapt to unexpected situations or events like drug shortages, recalls or system failures
- Maintain safe practices under stress

Why Hospitals Pursue High Reliability

- To reduce patient and staff harm in a high risk environment
- The complexity of healthcare operations combined with the risk of catastrophic outcomes
- Hospitals struggle to sustain improvements due to addressing multiple issues concurrently.

The Safety Culture Ladder



The Safety Culture Ladder

Where are we as an organization?

- **Level 1- Passive:** Errors are expected, unavoidable
- **Level 2- Reactive:** Address the issue only after they occur
- **Level 3 - Calculative:** Prevent problems, constantly monitoring for events
- **Level 4 - Proactive:** Anticipate problems before they occur
- **Level 5 - Generative:** Safety embedded in every aspect of care

Goal: Achieve a generative culture where quality and safety are our core values.

Question #1

Where is the pharmacy department on the culture ladder?

A. Passive

B. Reactive

C. Calculative

D. Proactive

E. Generative

Just Culture: A Foundation for High Reliability

Just culture is an organizational approach that balances accountability with learning, responding to incident in a fair and appropriate manner with a focus on system improvement.

Three Categories of Behavior:

Behavior Type	Example	Response
Human Error	Mistake, lapse, slip	Support, system improvement
At-risk Behavior	Taking shortcuts, workarounds	Coaching, education, remove barriers
Reckless Behavior	Conscious disregard for risk	Disciplinary action

Bottom line: Most errors are system failures and not individual failures

Two Conceptualizations of Just Culture

- **Retributive Justice Approach**
  - Traditional model with emphasis on individual's responsibility for failures
  - Enforced through sanctions and punishment
  - Promotes accountability but undermines safety

- **Restorative Justice Approach**
  - Model emphasizes the systemic and cultural perspective of incidents
  - Aims to foster learning conditions for groups and organizations

Key Elements of Just Culture Implementation

- Open communication and Multiple perspectives
- Room for Emotions
- Leadership commitment and exemplary behavior
- Fair and consistent response to errors

Core Principles of Just Culture

- Transparent and non punitive approach to errors
- Errors are viewed as learning opportunities and not to punish
- Accountability across all levels of the organization
- Focus on fixing systems, not blaming people

The result: Staff feel safe reporting errors and near misses, promotes system improvements.

Why Just Culture Matters

The Problem	The Solution	The Outcome
• Fear of consequences results in underreporting of errors • Underreporting prevents learning and improvement • Punitive cultures promotions unsafe system	• Staff feel safe reporting errors and concerns (psychological safety) • Trust: Fair and appropriate response by management • Learning: Errors become opportunities for improvement	• Increased reporting of near misses and close calls • Improved safety culture in the organization

Question #2

A pharmacist dispenses the wrong strength of a medication. The error is caught by the bedside nurse prior to administration.

What is the "Just Culture" approach to this situation?

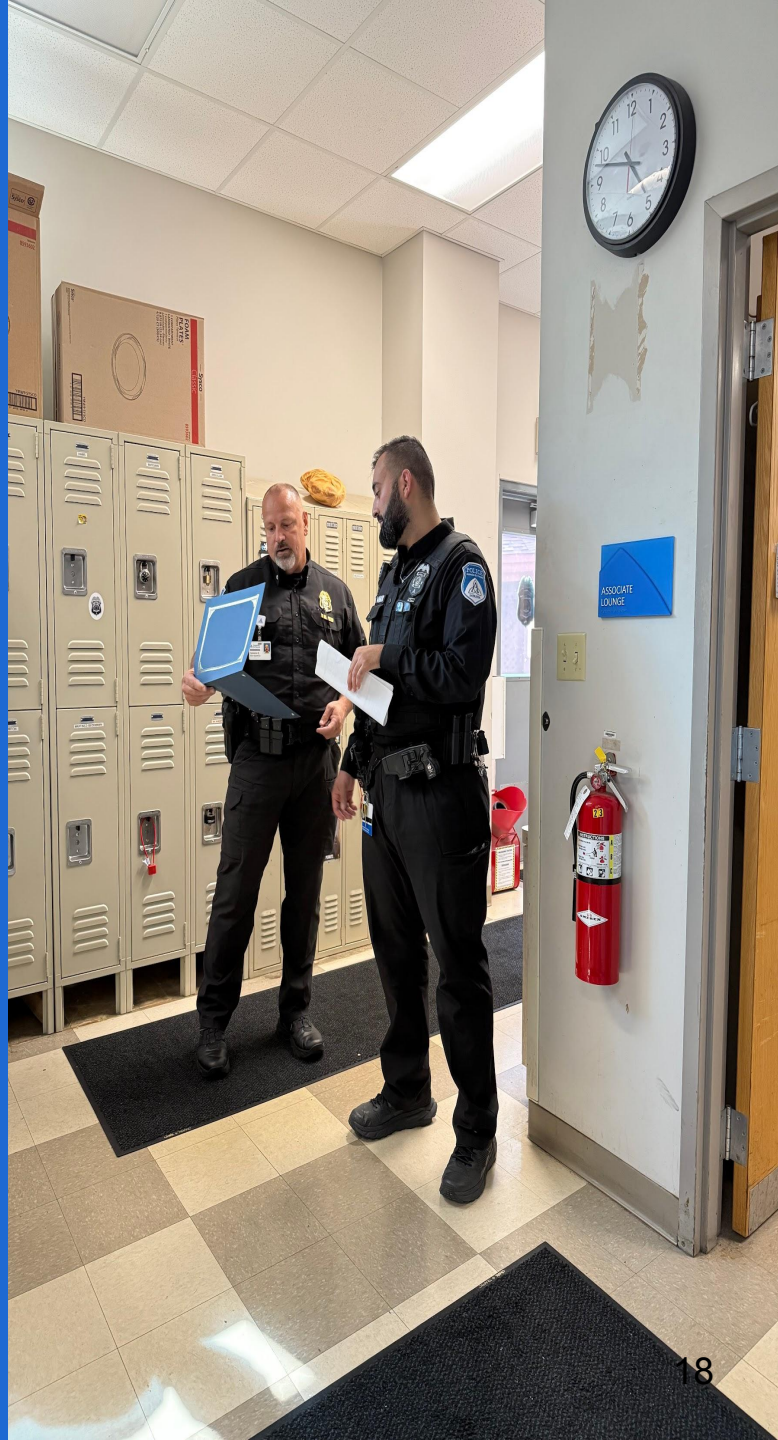
A. Discipline the pharmacist

B. Report the event and analyze system factors

C. Ignore the event since patient did not receive medication

D. Only document if the patient was harmed

Safety Behaviors



Safety Behavior: STAR (stop, think, act, review)

WE'VE GOT your back

SAFETY BEHAVIOR

STOP: Pause for 1-2 seconds to focus on the task at hand

THINK about the task at hand and visualize it. Do you need any additional information to perform it safely?

ACT: Concentrate on the task or gather the additional information so you can carry it out safely

REVIEW and check for the desired result.

- Self-checking tool
- We are all committed to safety
- We are all **200% accountable** for safe care: **100%** for ourselves and **100%** to each other.

Back to toolbox

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STAR Model Scenario

A pharmacy technician preparing a levophed notices that the concentration ordered by the provider differs from the standard protocol concentration.

What steps should this technician take?

STAR Model Scenario

A pharmacy technician preparing a levophed notices that the concentration ordered by the provider differs from the standard protocol concentration.

STAR Step	Action Taken	HRO Principle	Just Culture Element
STOP	Pause preparation upon recognizing discrepancy	Preoccupation with failure	Psychological safety enables tech stop workflow without fear
THINK	Consider if it was ordered in error? high alert medication which could compromise hemodynamic stability	Reluctance to simplify	Empowered to identify and act on complex situation without pressure
ACT	Contacts ICU pharmacist	Deference to expertise	Reporting encouraged as learning opportunity
REVIEW	Error confirmed, identify need for alert in order entry system	Sensitivity to operations	Focus on fixing system and not blaming provider

Our Commitment to Safety: What Can We Do Tomorrow

- Report every “near miss”
- Focus on the “why” and not the “who”
- Speak up regardless of Rank
- Support your colleagues
- Stop and analyze

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Questions?